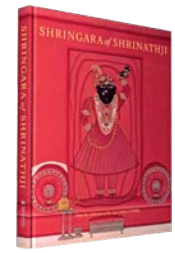
BOOKS

SHRINATHJI FOR ALL SEASONS

By showing 60 rare Nathdwara miniatures, a book does connoisseurs and devotees a favour





SHRINGARA OF SHRINATHJI: From the Collection of the Late Gokal Lal Mehta
by Amit Ambalal; conceptualised by Vikram Goyal
MAPIN PUBLISHING
₹9,500; 192 pages



The authority on Nathdwara paintings, Amit Ambalal, describes the varying adornment of the deity during its daily public viewings, and changing *Pichhvai* backdrops, raiment and regalia to reflect festivals and seasons

Of the many schools of sacred Indian art, there is none as vivid, captivating and instantly recognisable as that dedicated to Shrinathji, the "living" deity enshrined in the temple town of Nathdwara, near Udaipur. Either in the form of large painted backcloths, *pichhvais*, or small miniatures, the iconic images of the dark-faced, sumptuously bedecked manifestation of Krishna—that emerged in the 16th century by the Pushtimarg sect founded by Vallabhacharya—are much prized by museums and art collectors. Like infinite variations on a theme, the art of Nathdwara evokes the ever-changing adornment (*shringara*) of Shrinathji in the complex rituals of daily worship.

In more respects than one, this volume is a rarity. First, for its illuminating backstory. The cache of 60 miniatures, only 9 x 7 inches each, was made for a formidable personage—Pannalal Rai Mehta (1843-1919), an enlightened prime minister of Mewar (Udaipur) who served four *maharanas*. Pannalal was an ardent Shrinath devotee and art patron. Raja Ravi Varma painted him in a magnificent portrait that is reproduced here.

The miniatures were the creation of Sukhdev Kishandas Gaur, an exemplar of the golden age of Nathdwara painting, who worked in the late 19th century. The artist's acquaintance with European perspective and early photography adds verisimilitude to the architecture and portrait studies. One compelling image shows four generations of the Mehta family (*seen above*) worshipping at the altar of Shrinathji.

For decades, the valuable hoard lay in careful storage till a current descendant, Vikram Goyal, decided to make them public. Goyal was motivated by reasons both familial and art historical. "While growing up, I often heard my late maternal grandfather Gokal Lal Mehta, an IAS officer, wishfully romanticise that the family collection be published. They were in mint condition and very dear to him," says Goyal, a reputed product and interior designer. "I was also inspired by them in my own work. Despite their traditional ornament, they felt boldly modern in their pulsating design vocabulary of stripes, squares and chevrons."

Together with Bipin Shah of Mapin, Goyal conceived a limited-edition, large-format volume (each in its individual case). The paintings, interleaved with close-ups, glow to the highest standards of design layout and photographic reproduction. They enlisted the authority on Nathdwara painting, Amit Ambalal, author of the pioneering study *Krishna as Shrinathji: Rajasthani Paintings from Nathdwara* (Mapin, 1987) to write the text, describing the varying adornment of the deity during its eight public viewings a day, as well as changing *pichhvai* backdrops, raiment and regalia to reflect different festivals and seasons. In winter "the divine child" is swaddled in warm clothes, with ornate *shringaras* and deep colours; in summer, "the predominant colour is white [with] plenty of flowers." The iconography, too, is replete with symbolism: Shrinathji's lotus garland, for example, symbolises Radha's heart "that he keeps close to his own".

This high-value publication serves a purpose larger than being an art connoisseur or bibliophile's delight. It offers signal encouragement to privately-held collections to be placed in the public domain. ■

–Sunil Sethi